second?"

And they were still reluctant. So I said, "Then let's sign in alphabetical order. That still leaves me first and we can all say that the order of our names is merely alphabetical and has no other significance." And then they signed.

We then mailed off the letter and it was as though it had been dropped off into space. Nothing seemed to come of it.

7

On April 8, the specialists entered the barracks suddenly, with news for me. They had signed up for officers' training school. I had

been wondering where they were all day, and now I was both astonished and upset.

I told them that they were crazy; that they would be compelled to sign up for two years if they did that, whereas, as privates, they could strive continually for discharge.

Nonsense, they said, no one was getting discharged, and if they had to stay in the Army, they might as well be officers and comfortable. Besides, once they signed up they would get an instant furlough. If I signed up, I could get back at once to see Gertrude.

I held off, growing angrier by the minute, calling them traitors and renegades who had turned their back on the letter we had all sent off. I refused, despite all their blandishments, to join them. Even though it meant remaining behind in Operation Crossroads all alone, even though it meant missing the chance for quick reunion with Gertrude, I wouldn't sign up for officer training and wouldn't give up my drive for discharge.

And when I made it clear that nothing they could say would alter my opinion, they broke down and admitted it was a practical joke. They were going to pay me back for not pulling KP by luring me into attempting to sign up for officer training and making a fool of myself.

It took them quite a while to smooth my ruffled feathers, but I was secretly enormously pleased with myself. I had held to my principles!

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